



IN 1991-92, when Dhirubhai Ambani became India's first self-made dollar billionaire, he was nearly 60. The journey involved decades of licence-raj navigation and running textile mills and refineries.

Eight years later, Azim Premji joined the club when Wipro's IT valuation exploded during the dot-com boom. He was in his mid-50s.

Different decades, different sectors, same math—a billion-dollar net worth took almost a lifetime.

THE NEW CLOCK

26 | The median age of India's newest crop of self-made billionaires is 33. That's less than half the 67-year median age of the country's billionaire population overall. These entrepreneurs are not only young but have also built their empires from scratch, without the support of inherited wealth or family businesses.

That distinction matters more than it might seem. Look at the rest of India's rich list and a different pattern dominates—at the second generation, sons, daughters and nephews who took over conglomerates their previous generation built in steel, cement, pharmaceuticals or FMCG. Their wealth compounds through inherited market share, existing distribution networks, banking relationships built over decades, and boards populated by family loyalists. The job, for many of them, is stewardship: protecting and expanding a fortress that has already been built.

The founders in this story—all below 45—inherited none of that. No factory, no distribution network, no line of credit with a nationalised bank built on a grandfather's reputation. What they inherited instead was public and digital: a smartphone-owning population, a payments infrastructure anyone could plug into, an identity system that let a fintech company onboard a customer in minutes. Where a second-generation heir spends years learning to run what already exists, a self-made founder in this cohort had to first prove something existed at all—a market, a business model, a reason hundreds of millions of people would trust an app with their money. That is a fundamentally different apprenticeship, and it explains why their timelines look nothing alike even when their bank balances eventually do.

The question worth asking isn't who they are. It's what changed underneath them.

Three shifts converged to compress almost a lifetime journey into a decade or two—infrastructure (UPI, Aadhaar, cheap data), capital (a venture ecosystem that finally matured), and technology.

THE SMARTPHONE BOOM

Before UPI, before cheap data, there was the handset. Android phones flooded India as cheap as ₹5,000, and a population that had never owned a PC leapfrogged straight to mobile.

Two IIT graduates had already made their bet a couple of years earlier. Sachin Bansal and Binny Bansal started Flipkart as an online bookstore. The smartphone wave turned it into India's answer to Amazon. Cash on delivery for a cash economy, easy returns for a market that didn't trust buying the unseen.

Later, Walmart bought a majority stake in 2018 for roughly \$16 billion. The Bansals were still in their thirties. The playbook was written—find a fragmented offline market and digitise it with the help of venture capital faster than any incumbent could react.

THE KEY TRENDS

INDIA'S NEWEST CROP OF SELF-MADE BILLIONAIRES HAS A MEDIAN AGE OF 33. THAT'S LESS THAN HALF THE 67-YEAR MEDIAN AGE OF THE COUNTRY'S BILLIONAIRE POPULATION OVERALL

THESE ENTREPRENEURS ARE NOT ONLY YOUNG BUT HAVE ALSO BUILT THEIR EMPIRES FROM SCRATCH, WITHOUT THE SUPPORT OF INHERITED WEALTH OR FAMILY BUSINESS